

Timeline

A recently launched Google Labs experiment presents information already available in Google News organised and displayed chronologically

As of today the top 100 IRC networks serve more than half a million users at a time

TOOLBOX

Getting started with Xchat

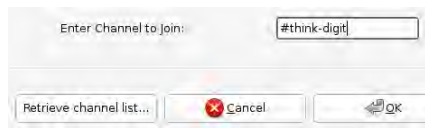


The 'User Information' dialog box in XChat. It contains fields for 'Nick name', 'Second choice', 'Third choice', 'User name', and 'Real name'. Below these is a 'Networks' section with a list of networks (EU-IRC, FDFNet, FEFNet, FreeNode, GalaxyNet, GamesNET, German-Elite) and buttons for 'Add', 'Remove', 'Edit...', and 'Sort'. There is also a checkbox for 'Skip network list on startup' and a 'Connect' button.

choose a network. Scroll through the list to view available networks. Click on a network (say FreeNode) and click connect. Once you are connected to the network or channel, you will have to select a channel to start chatting. Here, you have three options. One is to join a channel later. The second radio button allows you to specify a channel, preceded by #. This option can only be opted for if you know the channel name you want to join. The third option is to open the channel-list window, which will retrieve all the available channels.

Joining a channel

Joining a Channel in XChat



The 'Join Channel' dialog box in XChat. It has a text field 'Enter Channel to join:' with the value '#think-digit'. Below it are buttons for 'Retrieve channel list...', 'Cancel', and 'OK'.

Once you are in a network (eg FreeNode), click on Server > Join a Channel. Here, you can type the name of the channel preceded by a # sign e.g. #think-digit. You can also click on retrieve channel list. You will see a list of all the channels hosted on the server and the number of users in each channel. You can narrow down the list by entering a search keyword of your choice. Select the channel you want to join and click Join Channel. You can join multiple channels in the same way. Close window when done adding channels.

Get notified when a user joins the server

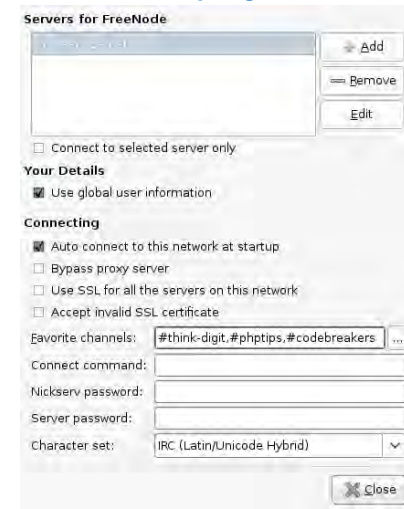
This can be done by adding a user to your friend list in Xchat. Right-click on the username and click "+Add to Friend List. Now whenever this user logs on to the server, you will get a notification, irrespective of the channel he is logged into. This is in effect the same as using the /notify command. To view the friendlist, click Window > Friend List.

Transparent background



Change Channel View (tree / tab)

Edit network for auto joining favourite channels



The 'Edit Network' dialog box in XChat. It has a title 'Servers for FreeNode'. It contains a list of servers with buttons for 'Add', 'Remove', and 'Edit'. Below the list are checkboxes for 'Connect to selected server only', 'Use global user information', 'Auto connect to this network at startup', 'Bypass proxy server', 'Use SSL for all the servers on this network', and 'Accept invalid SSL certificate'. There is a text field for 'Favorite channels:' with the value '#think-digit,#phptips,#codebreakers'. Below it are fields for 'Connect command:', 'Nickserver password:', 'Server password:', and a dropdown for 'Character set:' with the value 'IRC (Latin/Unicode Hybrid)'. There are 'Close' and 'OK' buttons.

XChat offers two choices of organising the channels you have joined. The views available are Tree and Tab view. To change the view go to View > Channel Switcher > Tab / Tree View.

IRC Commands

These are some common IRC commands that can be used with any IRC client, hence they are not specific to XChat

/HELP	General help or help on the given command.	/Help Ping
/LIST	Lists all current channels.	
/JOIN	To join a channel	/Join #think-digit
/LEAVE	To leave a channel	/Leave #justvhat
/QUIT	Exits your IRC session,	/Quit [reason]
/NICK	Changes your nickname	/Nick nonnewbie
/AWAY	Leaves a message saying you're away	/Away [Message]
/WHOIS	Displays information about someone	/Whois nonnewbie
/KICK	Kick someone off a channel (in operator mode)	/Kick [#Channel] [Nick]
/TOPIC	Changes the topic of the channel	/Topic [new topic]
/MSG	Sends a private message	/Msg [Nick]
/QUERY	Starts a private conversation	/Query [Nick]
/NOTIFY	Informs you when people logging in or out IRC	/Notify [Nick]
/IGNORE	Blocks responses of certain users	/Ignore [Nick]

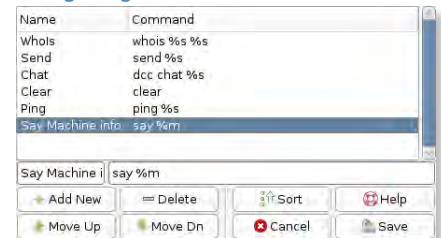
Change Background and Text colour

To change the look and feel of your interface, go to Settings > Preferences. Under Interface, you will find Colours. The "foreground" colour is your text colour while the "background" is your terminal colour. "Marking Text" is the selection or highlighting colour. You can also set transparent background. Enabling this option will show your desktop wallpaper. To do this, go to Settings > Preferences > Text box and check 'Transparent background'.

Auto join favourite channels on start up

You can have a number of channels that you can set for Xchat to join as soon as it starts up. To do this start up XChat or go to XChat > Network List or hit [Ctrl] + [S]. This will open up the Network List

Adding Dialog buttons



The 'Adding Dialog buttons' dialog box in XChat. It has a table with two columns: 'Name' and 'Command'. The table contains the following rows: 'Whois %s %s', 'Send %s', 'Chat %s', 'Clear %s', 'Ping %s', and 'Say Machine info: say %m'. Below the table are buttons for 'Add New', 'Delete', 'Sort', 'Help', 'Move Up', 'Move Down', 'Cancel', and 'Save'.

Box. Select a Network and click Edit. Check the box for "Auto connect to this network on start up". Enter favourite channels separated by commas. For example, #think-digit, #phptips, #codebreakers. Click close.

Add private chat buttons

To be able to have private chat with any user click on the username, right click and click